Recency knob — a control surface, not a winner

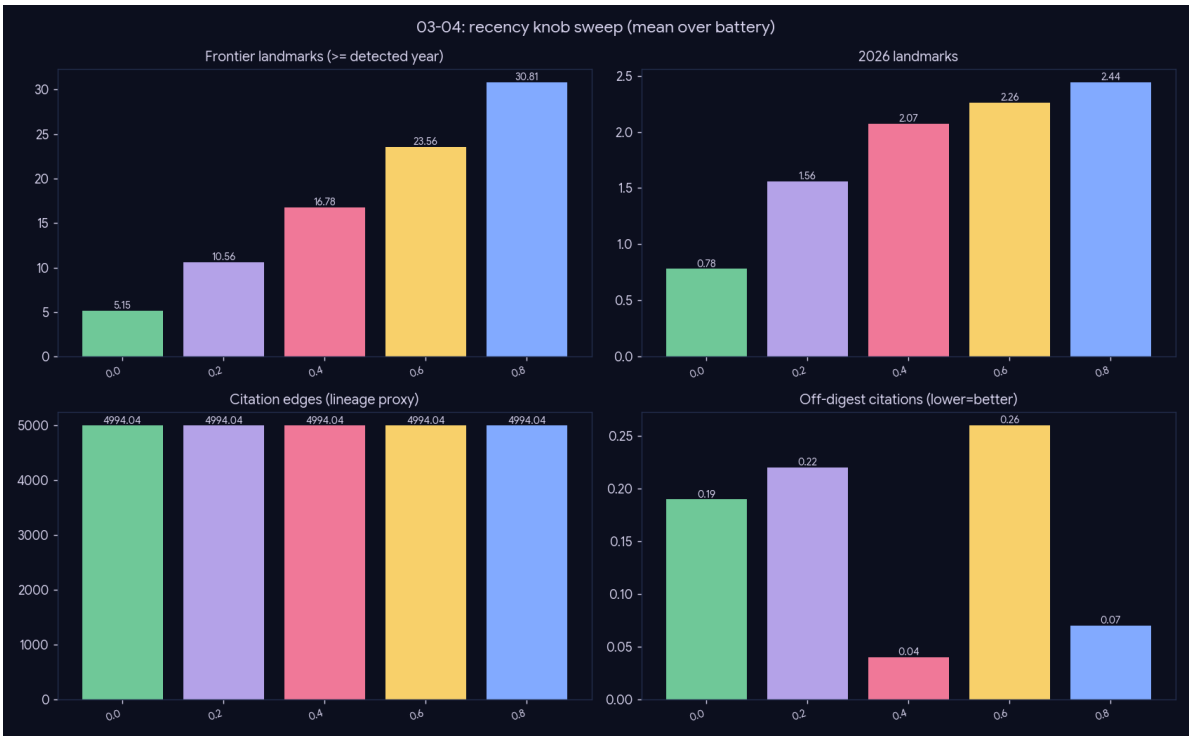
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What we did

Sweep the topic-adaptive recency knob `recency` $\in \{0.0, 0.2, 0.4, 0.6, 0.8\}$ over the 27-topic battery. The knob dials how many landmark slots are reserved newest-cohort-first (frontier) versus left to PPR lineage ranking; the frontier *year* is auto-detected per topic from its own histogram, so the knob is a relative dial, not an absolute year.

Results (mean over 27 topics)

recency	frontier count	ge 2025	n 2026	n edges	grounded	off digest	landmark recall
0.0	5.15	1.26	0.78	4994.04	21.11	0.19	0.09
0.2	10.56	4.0	1.56	4994.04	22.07	0.22	0.09
0.4	16.78	7.0	2.07	4994.04	23.74	0.04	0.09
0.6	23.56	9.7	2.26	4994.04	23.85	0.26	0.05
0.8	30.81	12.59	2.44	4994.04	22.37	0.07	0.04



Conclusion

Recency is a control surface, not a lever with a single optimum. Frontier landmarks climb monotonically with the knob (5.15 at 0.0 → 30.81 at 0.8) while `grounded` stays roughly flat (∼22–25)

and `off_digest` stays low throughout — i.e. the knob trades *lineage depth for frontier coverage at constant grounding*, exactly as designed. There is no universal best value: a "foundations of X" question wants low recency (lineage), a "latest in X" question wants high. So it is correctly *exposed* as a per-query knob with a sensible mid default, not tuned to a constant. **Caveat:** `landmark_recall` is diluted by the non-gold topics and is flat here; the meaningful signal is the monotonic frontier/lineage trade, which is clean.